3.3 The War Ends

How often does winning against impossible odds happen in real life? When that first shot was fired in Lexington, no one could have predicted that 13 small colonies would defeat one of the world's greatest armies.

MAIN IDEA The British defeat at the Battle of Yorktown brought an end to the American Revolution.

A PIVOTAL YEAR

As you've read, British hopes for victory in the South began to fade after their defeat at Kings Mountain. In 1781, American general Nathanael Greene moved south to regain South Carolina and Georgia, where the British still had 8,000 men spread thinly throughout the large region. Greene's 1,500 Continental soldiers and the guerilla units helping them were able to defeat small groups one by one. Americans were able to take back most of the area. Meanwhile, in Virginia, Lord Cornwallis replaced Benedict Arnold as commander of the British forces in the area. In Yorktown, with an army of almost 8,000 men, Cornwallis camped on a peninsula facing the York River. His aim was to protect the harbor for the use of the British fleet. Cornwallis requested more troops from New York, but the British were slow in sending them.

U.S. Capitol Rotunda, Washington, D.C.

John Trumbull's painting *Surrender of Lord Cornwallis* depicts the British surrender in Yorktown. In the painting, American troops (on the right) and French troops (on the left) are all on horseback. Cornwallis's soldiers appear in the center of the painting. Why do you think the British soldiers are all on foot?



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Setting up camp on the peninsula would prove to be a fatal mistake for Lord Cornwallis and his soldiers.

THE WORLD TURNED UPSIDE DOWN

American and French troops surrounded Cornwallis's camp by land and by sea. French naval officer admiral Comte de Grasse (duh-GRAHS) commanded a French fleet on the York River. He approached the British camp from the water. Meanwhile, a combined army of French soldiers, commanded by Comte de Rochambeau (ROH-sham-BOH), and Americans, led by General George Washington, marched south from New York, approaching the camp by land. In a show of military **expertise**, or skill, these three commanders led their 17,000 troops against Cornwallis, trapping him on the peninsula. Cornwallis had no choice but to surrender.

Charles O'Hara, second in command to Cornwallis, tried to surrender his general's sword to Rochambeau, but the French leader steered him to Washington instead. The British military band played a song called "The World Turned Upside Down," a fitting comment on the victory. The **Battle of Yorktown** was the last major battle of the war. In 1782, more than six years after the first shots were fired, the British Parliament officially voted to end the war.

The impact of this victory was staggering. Once only the dream of a group of visionaries seeking freedom from unreasonable laws and taxes, the young country had come through the fire of war to take its place as a full-fledged nation. In the decades and centuries that followed, the United States of America—established with the promise of equality for all—would rise to become one of the most powerful and influential nations on Earth. In time, people in many countries around the world would draw inspiration from America's example and fight for their own freedom and independence.



Remembering the Victors

This stamp commemorates the 150th anniversary of the victory at Yorktown. We all know George Washington, who is shown in the middle, but what about the other two leaders who helped the Americans win at Yorktown?

Comte de Rochambeau (on the left), was born in Vendôme, France. Commissioned into the French army at age 17, he was a veteran of 14 military sieges in Europe. King Louis XVI sent him to lead the French force in America in 1780.

Comte de Grasse (on the right), was born in Le Bar, France, and started working on ships when he was only about 12 years old. At 18, he joined the French navy. DeGrasse was fighting the British in the West Indies when General Washington asked for his help in Virginia against Cornwallis. The rest is history.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What factors led to the American victory at Yorktown?
2. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** What statement was Rochambeau making when he made O'Hara surrender the British general's sword to Washington?
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What happened as a result of the American victory in both the long- and short-term?

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